PHONE SALES PLAYBOOK

Closing Pacific Cascade Legal

Using the NEPQ Framework

Neuro-Emotional Persuasion Questioning

85% Engagement · 10% Presentation · 5% Commitment

PersonalBranding.com

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The NEPQ Framework for Phone Sales

NEPQ (Neuro-Emotional Persuasion Questioning) flips the traditional sales call. Instead of pitching and hoping, you ask skilled questions that help the prospect **sell themselves**. The prospect discovers their own problem, feels the consequences, and arrives at the conclusion that they need to act. You barely need to "present" at all.

THE NEPQ TIME SPLIT (Matt Ryder / Jeremy Miner)

85% ENGAGEMENT — Connection + Situation + Problem Awareness + Solution Awareness + Consequence

10% PRESENTATION — Brief explanation of how we solve it (NOT a pitch deck or screen share)

5% COMMITMENT — Next steps, close, or handle objections

This is a phone call, not a Zoom. No screen sharing, no slide decks, no reports. The competitive analysis report is your pre-call research—it informs your questions, but you never show it to the prospect. You use the data conversationally to ask questions that make them realize they have a problem.

MATT RYDER'S KEY PRINCIPLE

The engagement stage is the core of NEPQ. It's 85% of the new model of selling. Your prospects buy from you based on your skills of listening, being understanding, and asking them the right questions at the right time. Your questions empower them to get in touch with their emotional feelings about their situation and want to do something about it.

1 Connection Phase

~5%

Goal: Disarm them. Take the focus off you and put it on them. You're not pitching—you're a human being having a conversation about their business.

Opening (Tone: Calm, Curious, Slightly Detached)

SAY THIS

> *"Hey Lewis, this is [Name] with PersonalBranding.com. I appreciate you taking a few minutes. Before I take up any of your time—can I ask you a couple quick questions just to see if what we do would even make sense for a firm like yours? And if it doesn't, I'll be the first one to tell you."*

WHY THIS WORKS

This is a classic NEPQ connecting question. You're doing three things: (1) giving them an out so they don't feel trapped, (2) positioning yourself as someone who might NOT sell them, which drops their guard, and (3) getting permission to ask questions, which gives you control of the call.

IF THEY ASK "WHAT IS THIS ABOUT?"

> *"Totally fair question. We work with law firms on their media presence—basically how they show up when prospective clients Google them. I did some research on your firm before reaching out, and I had a couple observations I wanted to run by you. Would that be alright?"*

2 Situation Phase ~10%

Goal: Understand where they are right now. What are they currently doing for marketing, PR, and visibility? Let them talk. You're gathering intel.

Situation Questions

QUESTION 1

> *"So Lewis, I'm curious—when it comes to getting your firm's name out there beyond word of mouth and your website, what are you guys currently doing for that right now?"*

QUESTION 2

> *"And in terms of press or media coverage—being featured on news sites, being quoted as an expert, that kind of thing—is that something your firm has invested in at all? Or has it mostly been organic up to this point?"*

QUESTION 3

> *"Where are the majority of your new clients coming from right now? Is it mostly referrals, Google searches, something else?"*

COACHING NOTE

Listen more than you talk here. Their answers tell you exactly which problem awareness questions to lean into. If they say "it's all referrals," you'll use that in the consequence phase. If they say "we've tried some stuff," dig into what didn't work. Every answer is a doorway to the next question.

3 Problem Awareness Phase ~25%

Goal: Help them discover the problem THEMSELVES. This is where your competitive research becomes powerful—but you're not "presenting" it. You're asking questions that lead them to the realization.

Leading Into the Competitive Gap

QUESTION 4

> *"So I have to ask you something—and this is kind of what caught my attention when I was doing research on your firm. When you think about the other family law firms in your market—firms like Gevurtz Menashe, or Stahancyk Kent and Hook—would you say you guys are pretty well-known compared to them? Or do you feel like there's some ground to make up there?"*

WHY THIS WORKS

You're naming their competitors. This immediately gets personal. Most business owners have strong feelings about their competitors. By asking if they feel like there's ground to make up, you're letting them admit the gap themselves—which is 10x more powerful than you telling them.

QUESTION 5

> *"That makes sense. One thing I noticed when I was looking into this—and I found this really interesting—when you Google some of those other firms, they show up in actual news articles and media outlets. Like Gevurtz Menashe's co-founder was the Oregon State Bar President, and they've been featured all over legal publications for years. Have you noticed that kind of media presence from your competitors?"*

QUESTION 6

> *"And when you look at your own firm—with eight offices and over 340 Google reviews, which is incredible by the way—do you feel like that story is being told anywhere beyond your own website and social media?"*

DIG DEEPER

> *"How long would you say that's been a gap? Like, has the press and media side ever been something you guys tried to tackle?"*

KEY INSIGHT

You're NOT saying "your competitors have 3–5x more media coverage." You're asking questions that lead them to that conclusion themselves. The prospect's own words are always more persuasive than yours. If they say "yeah, we've never really focused on that," they just told themselves they have a problem.

4 Solution Awareness Phase ~20%

Goal: Help them articulate what the ideal solution would look like. You're not pitching yet. You're getting THEM to describe what they need.

QUESTION 7

> *"So if you could wave a magic wand and fix this tomorrow—like, if Pacific Cascade Legal started showing up in news outlets the same way your competitors do—what would that mean for the firm? How would that change things?"*

QUESTION 8

> *"When a potential client is deciding between you and another firm—and they Google both names—what do you think would happen if your name came up in news articles and media features, and the other firm's didn't? How do you think that changes the dynamic?"*

QUESTION 9

> *"Have you guys ever tried working with a PR firm or doing press releases before? What happened with that?"*

COACHING NOTE

If they've tried PR before and it didn't work, that's GOLD. Ask what went wrong. It sets up your differentiation perfectly when you get to the presentation. If they haven't tried anything, ask why not—the answer usually reveals the real objection (cost, didn't think it mattered, didn't know where to start).

5 Consequence Phase

~25%

Goal: This is the emotional peak of the call. Help them feel the cost of NOT fixing this. What happens if they stay invisible while their competitors keep building media presence? This creates internal urgency—not from you pressuring them, but from them realizing the consequences themselves.

QUESTION 10

> *"So let me ask you this—if nothing changes and things stay the way they are right now with the media and visibility side—and meanwhile firms like Gevurtz Menashe keep getting press and keep showing up in the news—where do you see that gap being in another year or two?"*

QUESTION 11

> *"And you mentioned that a lot of your clients come from referrals—which is great. But when those referred prospects Google you before they pick up the phone, and they see one firm in the news and one firm that's not—how do you think that affects their decision? Even subconsciously?"*

QUESTION 12

> *"I'm curious—have you guys noticed that AI tools like ChatGPT and Google's AI are starting to recommend specific attorneys when people search? Those tools are pulling heavily from media coverage to decide who to recommend. If your competitors are in the news and you're not—what do you think happens when that becomes the main way people find an attorney?"*

MATT RYDER'S PRINCIPLE IN ACTION

The consequence questions make the prospect state out loud what happens if they don't act. This is NOT fear-based selling. You're helping them see reality clearly. Their own answers create the urgency. When done right, by the end of this phase they're practically asking you "so what can we do about this?"

THE BRIDGE QUESTION (TRANSITION TO PRESENTATION)

> *"Based on everything you're telling me—it sounds like having a real media presence is something that would make a big difference for the firm. Would it be helpful if I explained how we actually solve this for law firms like yours? It'll only take a minute or two."*

WHY YOU ASK PERMISSION

You're getting them to invite the presentation. They're not being pitched—they're asking you to explain. This completely changes the dynamic. They're leaning in, not leaning back.

6 Presentation Phase

~10%

CRITICAL: THIS IS 10% OF THE CALL. Two to three minutes MAX. You are not doing a demo. You are not screen sharing. You are not walking through a report. You are on a phone call. Keep this tight, conversational, and directly tied to what THEY just told you.

THE 60-SECOND EXPLANATION

"So here's what we do in a nutshell. We get your firm published on real news and media outlets—places like Forbes, USA Today, Yahoo, MSN, NBC affiliates, FOX affiliates—the kinds of places that Google and AI tools trust. We handle everything—the writing, the placement, the publishing. You don't have to pitch anyone or write anything. Within 30 to 60 days, when someone Googles your firm, they see Pacific Cascade Legal in the news—not just on your own website."

Tie It Back to THEIR Words

CONNECT TO THEIR ANSWERS

"You mentioned earlier that [repeat something specific they said—e.g., 'your clients mostly come from referrals and you've never really focused on press']. What this does is give those referral prospects a reason to choose you the moment they Google your name. And you mentioned the gap with firms like Gevurtz Menashe—this is literally how you close that gap."

KEY: REFERENCE THEIR WORDS, NOT YOUR PITCH

Notice you're not listing features. You're reflecting their own language back to them and explaining how you solve what THEY said was the problem. This is what Matt Ryder means by "presenting by not presenting."

7 Commitment Phase

~5%

Goal: Get a clear next step. Either they move forward now, or you lock in a specific follow-up action and date.

The Natural Close

SAY THIS

> *"So based on everything you shared with me today—and it really does sound like this is the missing piece for the firm—how would you like to proceed from here?"*

WHY THIS PHRASING

You're not asking "do you want to buy?" You're asking them to tell you the next step. This is NEPQ commitment—you let them direct the close. Their answer tells you exactly where they are.

If They're Ready

SAY THIS

> *"Great. Here's what the first step looks like—[walk through your onboarding process and pricing]. We can get the first articles in motion within the first week."*

If They Need to Think About It

SAY THIS

> *"That makes total sense. Can I ask—what specifically are you wanting to think over? Is it the approach itself, or is it more about budget and timing?"*

(Diagnose the objection. Then address it. See objection handling section below.)

If You Need a Follow-Up

SAY THIS

> *"Tell you what—why don't I put together a quick custom plan for Pacific Cascade Legal specifically—just the first batch of article angles, which outlets they'd go on. That way when we reconnect you're looking at something concrete, not deciding in the abstract. What day works better for you—[Day A] or [Day B]?"*

ALWAYS GET A SPECIFIC DATE

Never end a call with “I’ll send this over and you can get back to me.” That’s where deals go to die. Lock a date. Lock a time. Put it on the calendar while you’re still on the phone.

NEPQ Objection Handling

In NEPQ, objections aren't roadblocks—they're invitations to ask better questions. Never argue. Always respond with a question that helps them work through it themselves.

"We already have a marketing agency."

RESPONSE

> *"That's great. Can I ask—what is your agency currently doing in terms of getting you actual published media placements on third-party news sites? Like articles on Yahoo or USA Today about your firm? ... [They'll likely say nothing or very little.] ... Yeah, that's actually really common. Most marketing agencies handle your website, SEO, ads, social—but they don't do actual media placements. What we do sits on top of all of that. It doesn't replace anything your agency is doing—it adds a layer they're not providing."*

"We get most of our business from referrals."

RESPONSE

> *"That's actually a great position to be in. Can I ask though—when someone gets your name as a referral, what's the first thing they typically do before they call you? ... [They'll say Google.] ... Right. So the question becomes—when they Google you, and then Google your competitor, what do they see? If one firm is all over the news and the other isn't—even a strong referral can start to second-guess. Does that resonate at all?"*

"What kind of publications? Are they legit?"

RESPONSE

> *"That's the right question to ask. We're talking outlets like Forbes, USA Today, Yahoo, MSN, and local TV affiliates like NBC, FOX, and CBS. These are real newsrooms that Google indexes in their News tab—which is what gives the placements their SEO value and credibility. Happy to share specific examples of what past placements look like if that would be helpful."*

"Let me think about it."

RESPONSE

> *"Of course—can I ask, what part specifically is weighing on you? Is it whether this approach would work for a family law firm, or is it more about the investment and timing? ... [Listen. Then address*

> *whatever the real concern is.] ... I only ask because if there's something specific I can clarify right now, I'd rather do that than have you wondering about it for a few days. And if the timing just isn't right, I'll be straight with you about that too."*

"What does this cost?"

RESPONSE

> *"[Share pricing.] ... And just to put it in context—Gevurtz Menashe has been building their media presence for decades. Their co-founder spent years earning the Oregon Bar Presidency to get that kind of coverage. We can put Pacific Cascade Legal on the same level in 30 to 60 days. The question is really—if one new client comes in because they saw you in the news instead of your competitor, what's that case worth? For most family law firms, a single case covers the investment multiple times over."*

Pre-Call Prep Checklist

Complete before every call. This is a phone call—all of this lives in your notes, not on a screen share.

- **Competitive analysis report reviewed and key stats memorized** (3–5x gap, Gevurtz Menashe at 15–25 mentions, SKH Wikipedia, GRM smaller but 2–3x more press)
- **Prospect's name, role, and background noted** (Lewis Landerholm, Founding Partner, founded 2010)
- **Key firm stats memorized** (8 offices, 10+ attorneys, 340+ Google reviews, Modern Family Matters podcast, Best of Willamette Valley 3 years running)
- **Top 3 competitor names ready to drop naturally** (Gevurtz Menashe, Stahancyk Kent & Hook, Gearing Rackner & McGrath)
- **2–3 specific media examples memorized** (Albert Menashe OSB President, SKH in Willamette Week for paralegal licensing, GRM on Fox2Now)
- **Article angle ideas ready if asked** (founder story, award coverage, podcast spotlight, expansion to Tacoma, single parent advocacy)
- **Pricing and package details accessible**
- **Calendar open for booking follow-ups on the spot**

Post-Call Follow-Up (Phone/Email)

Same Day (Within 1 Hour)

Send a short text or email. Keep it personal and brief:

EMAIL/TEXT

> *"Hey Lewis — great chatting today. As promised, I'm going to put together a quick custom plan with article angles specific to Pacific Cascade Legal. I'll have that over to you by [day]. Talk soon."*

Day 2–3: Custom Article Angles

Send 5–10 article topic ideas. No fluff—just headlines and one-line descriptions. Make it tangible. They should be able to picture these articles existing.

Day 5: Follow-Up Call

Call, don't email. Keep it short:

SAY THIS

> *"Hey Lewis, it's [Name] from PersonalBranding.com. Just wanted to make sure you saw the article plan I sent over. Did any of those angles stand out to you? ... [Let them talk.] ... Would it make sense to get the first batch started?"*

Day 10: Final Touch

If no response, one last short text or voicemail. Low pressure, high value:

SAY THIS

> *"Hey Lewis — just circling back one more time. No pressure at all. If the timing isn't right, I totally get it. But I did notice [competitor name] just put out another press release this week, so I wanted to keep this on your radar. Happy to reconnect whenever it makes sense."*

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

You are not selling media placements. You are helping Lewis realize that his firm's incredible work—the 8 offices, the podcast, the 340 reviews, the awards—is **invisible to the people who matter most**. His competitors are visible. He's not. Your questions help him feel that gap. The sale follows naturally.

Ask. Listen. Let them sell themselves.